

Single syllable sounds

As mentioned in the rhyme, the sound of the *ie* or *ei* can be used to figure out which letter combination is right. There are four main rules to remember if the *ie/ei* is pronounced as one syllable. However, most of the rules have exceptions, which have to be learned.

Rule 1

If the sound is “ee,” the *i* goes before the *e*.

niece, belief, achieve, field

There are numerous exceptions to this rule that have to be learned.

protein, seize, either, leisure, caffeine

Rule 2

If the “ee” sound follows the letter *c*, the *e* goes first.

receive, receipt, deceit, ceiling

One exception to this rule is when the *ci* sounds like “sh.”

ancient, conscience, species

The rule also doesn't apply to words ending in *y* that have been modified.

fancied, policies, bouncier

Rule 3

The *e* goes before the *i* if the sound is “ay” or “eye.”

eight, height, feisty

Sometimes, the “eye” sound can also be heard when the *i* goes before *e*.

die, pie, lie, cried

Rule 4

The *e* goes before the *i* if the sound is “eh,” as in *met*.

heifer, their, heir

exceptions to this rule

friend, unfriendly

Double syllable sounds

If the *i* and *e* are pronounced as two different sounds, it's easy to figure out which letter comes first. If the “i” sound is pronounced first, then the *i* comes first in the spelling, and vice versa.

**di-et, a-li-en,
sci-ence, so-ci-e-ty**

Pronounced *i* then *e*

In these words, the *i* syllable is said first, so the *i* comes first in the spelling.

**de-i-ty, see-ing, be-ing,
re-ig-nite, here-in**

Pronounced *e* then *i*

In these words, the *e* syllable is said first, so the *e* comes first in the spelling.